



I'm in extreme pain!

Social Information Modulates
Intensifier Interpretation

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Contact Me!



Social & pragmatic meaning

Pragmatic variables carry social information¹

Speaker information influences pragmatic processing²

Do pragmatic interpretations vary based on a speaker's race/gender in a high-stakes environment?

The context and variable

People can linguistically **discriminate** based on their voice, dialect, or linguistic variable usage³



Speaking in a different dialect → less housing callbacks³



Speaking with an accent → less likely to be hired^{4,5}



Speaking with an accent → less trustworthy and credible^{6,7}

Physicians also have **negative** perceptions of a patient (PT) based on the PT's race and gender:

Negative Perceptions of PTs

Black (vs. White) PTs

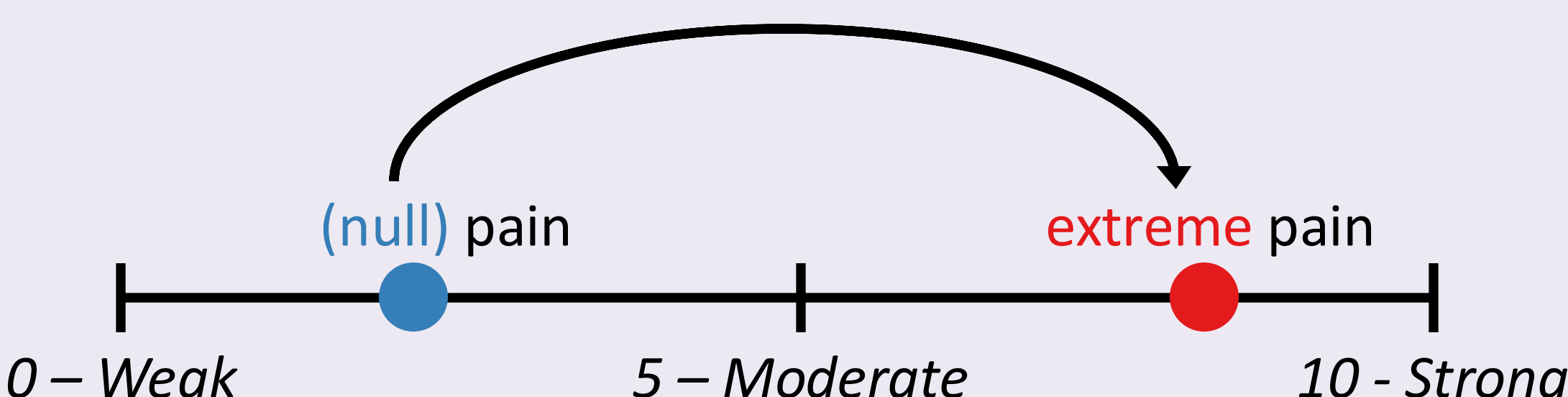
- Overly high pain tolerance⁸
- Understate pain⁸
- Distrusted pain reports⁹

Women (vs. Men) PTs

- Low pain tolerance^{8,10}
- Exaggerate pain^{8,10}
- Distrusted pain reports¹⁰

Black PTs and women may **emphasize symptoms** to be taken seriously¹¹, e.g., by using **intensifiers**

Intensifiers^{12,13} also have negative perceptions, often associated with women's language¹⁴ and hyperbole¹⁵



How'd we do it?

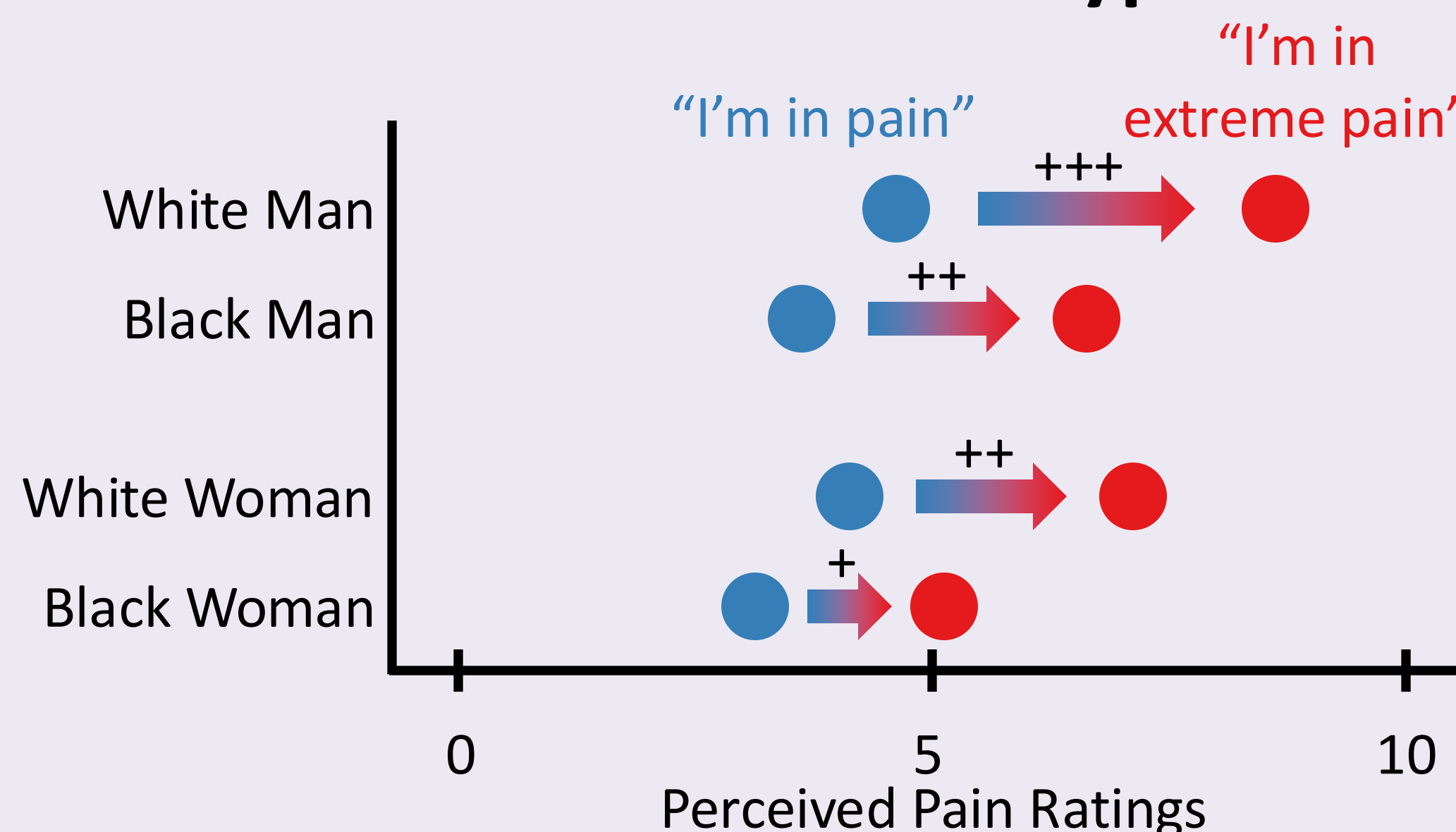
54 physicians read a hypothetical symptom report, which manipulated Race (Black vs. White), Gender (man vs. woman), and Intensity:

- Three intensifiers ("intense", "extreme", "severe") all absent (**bare**) or present (**intense**) from report

Participants rated perceived pain on an 11-point Likert Scale

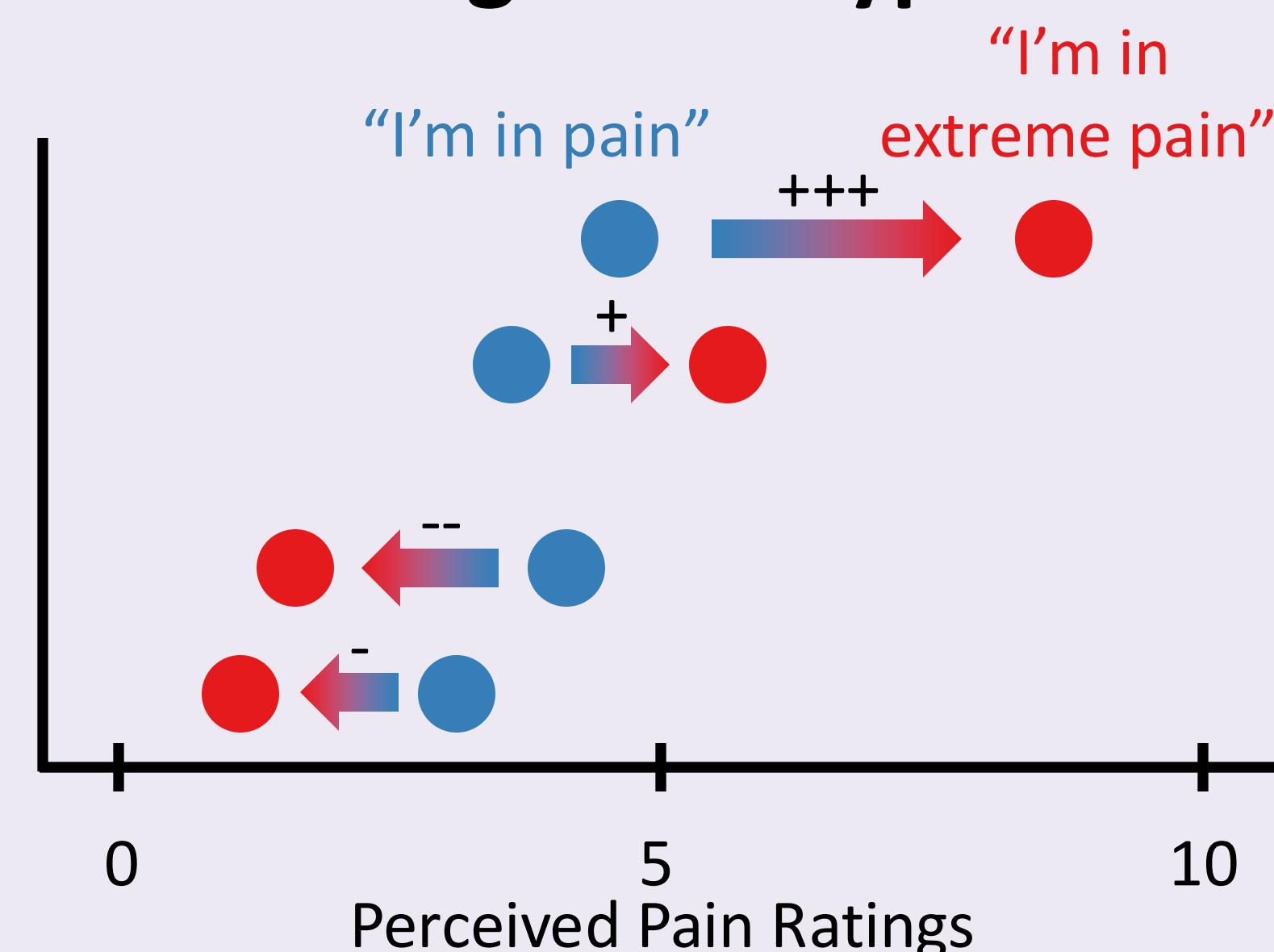
Different ways intensifiers could be interpreted

Socio-Semantic Hypothesis



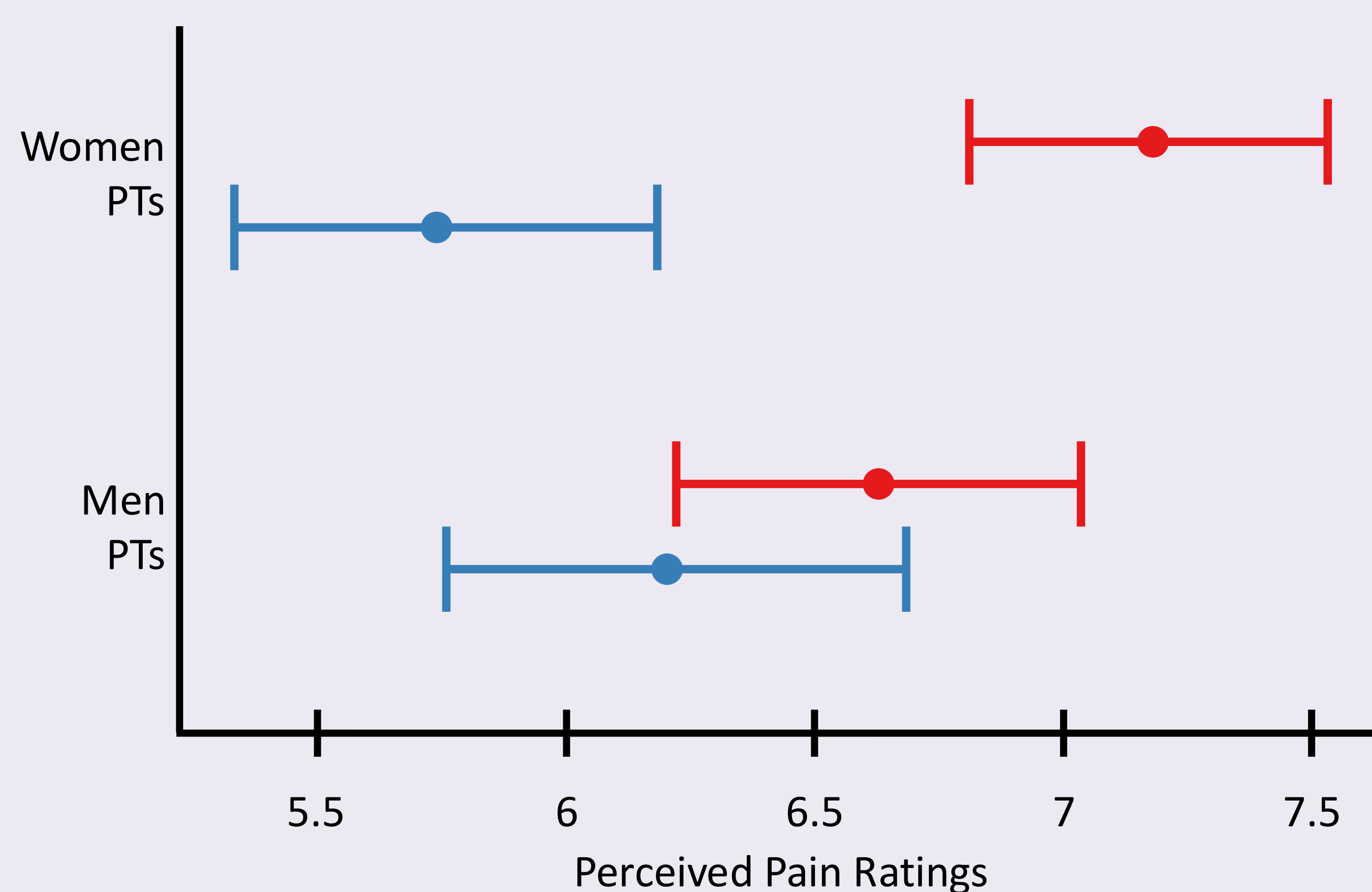
Physicians will increase pain ratings *more* for White patients and men than for Black patients⁸ and women¹⁰

Socio-Pragmatic Hypothesis



Physicians will increase pain ratings for White patients and men but *decrease* ratings¹⁵ for Black patients⁹ and women¹⁰

Physicians rated pain differently based on intensity and gender



Intense vs. **Bare** rated **significantly different for women** but not men ($p < .01$)

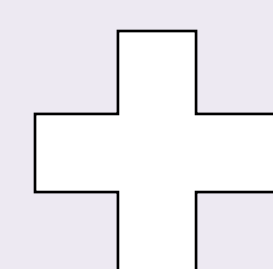
Physicians generally disbelieve and dismiss women for their pain¹⁶ and potentially took women more seriously **only** when they emphasized pain

Women: "I'm in pain" 5.74/10

Women: "I'm in extreme pain" 7.19/10

Social factors *do* impact meaning resolution and should be incorporated into theories of linguistic meaning

Social Information (Gender)



Linguistic Choices (Intensifier Usage)

Pain perception increases +

Pain perception increases +++

Citations & Acknowledgements



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